

Diploma in Leadership & Management

**We are going virtual**



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## Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of virtual meetings. The students will be able to improve their own virtual meetings. The students will also be able to create a better inclusion program when hosting virtual meetings based on the lesson material.

## Introduction



The way business is conducted is always changing and so is the need for managers and leaders to keep changing and be adaptable

Virtual and remote business tools are impacting the way we have to look at business, how we work with customers and how teams are led.

According to (Chron) In a recent survey, more than half of respondents said they worked remotely. Another 28 percent worked partially remotely, partially on-site. Marketing and PR, design, engineering, sales and customer support jobs are among the most popular choices for remote workers.

Innovative apps and video chat services like Trello, Slack and Asana contribute to this trend. Nowadays, teams worldwide can share files, hold online meetings and collaborate on the go. Today's workforce is no longer tied to an office location and can work from virtually anywhere. We're witnessing the rise of new technologies that promote a flexible work culture and improve communication.

Whether you're a startup or a multinational organization, you can use online meeting tools to streamline collaboration and create a better work-life balance for your team. Setting up a virtual meeting is much easier and less time-consuming than traveling miles away from your office. Your employees can share data and project ideas with the click of a button without the need to leave home. This will not only boost their productivity and motivation but also drive employee efficiency and engagement.

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## Key reading materials:

- <https://www.pmi.org/learning/library/successful-virtual-meetings-skills-improvement-6267>
- <https://insights.learnlight.com/en/articles/8-tips-more-effective-virtual-meetings/>

## Run a successful virtual meeting:



According to (Frisch, n.d.) as employees work remotely, employees need managers and leaders to step up and create a safe environment where employees can meet and get work done. Virtual meetings should take into account the needs of the different participants in order to have a successful virtual meeting. Take the following steps into account when hosting virtual meetings:

### Use video:

Make sure that people are able to see each other. People feel more connected with video meetings than just voice meetings. You can mix it up with both video and voice meetings but make sure that the majority of your meetings are video based.

### Provide and audio dial-in option:

If the video option fails, employees need to know that they can dial in via their audio function. The idea is that you are being proactive and that you have steps in place to help the meeting continue regardless of internet connection. But keep in mind that the video option should take preference.

### Test tech ahead of time:

Always make sure to test your mic and camera before the meeting. Make sure to also ask your employees to test their tech before the meeting. Remind the employees if there are any updates or if there are common issues that everyone is mentioning.

### Stick to the basics:

Set clear objectives and pre-reading material before the meeting. You have to follow the same steps and approaches you would have for in-person meetings. It takes the same amount of planning and work to conduct a virtual meeting. Think of

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things like an agenda, setting boundaries, take breaks and set clear plans based on what was discussed during the meeting.

### Make it time efficient:

Meetings can get frustrating in-person and online. Make sure that you have your meeting planned and that you consider that people will chat and share ideas. Rather make the meeting shorter but really efficient than long and people getting frustrated and not taking in the information.

### Call on people:

Getting everyone involved is a key part of running a virtual meeting. The issue comes in when everyone wants to speak and they start to speak over each other. You can overcome this issue by calling on people to speak in order to give everyone a chance. This way everyone gets a turn, there is more order and control and you avoid the issue of people speaking over each other. This is a great tip that will help your introverted employees feel supported and that they get a chance to collaborate and share their input.

### Spot check:

After some of your virtual meetings, make sure to seek out feedback. You can give a few of the participants to gain more feedback. This is a great way to gain real-time feedback about how the meetings are going and where you can improve as the leader or manager.

## Virtual meeting issues and barriers:



According to (Demo Desk , n.d.) Did you know that the majority of workers experience that up to 95% of meetings start late?

When meetings do not start on time, the team and company lose valuable time and money. If you host a meeting, it is up to you to start and end that meeting on time.

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According to (Ovum) the average employee meeting 8 times per week and executives in high tech industries can meet up to 17 times. 1/3 meetings are not virtual as the need for remote offices and teams grows in popularity. A study released by IWG revealed that 70% of professionals work remotely at least one day a week, while 53% work remotely for at least half of the week.

67% of employees report that more than half of the meetings they attend are not of value. Key reasons are late start times. The vast majority of workers experience that up to 95% of meetings start late. This leads to an unacceptable number of meetings that are perceived to have no value and is costing executives about 3 hours every week in lost time and productivity. The number of lost hours each week sums up to incredible five 24-hour days and 19 hours per year.

Here are the following issues and barriers that impact the quality and effectiveness of your virtual meetings:

### **Corporate firewall or incompatible browser blocking use of conferencing software**

More modern conferencing providers are already trying to address the download issue. Even though the host is always required to install a software on-premise, they provide guests with the ability to join the meeting via a web client that runs from the browser. However, those clients often work only with the most recent Chrome and Firefox versions. If you are running on an older version or use Internet Explorer, you're out of the game. Corporate firewalls also frequently block web clients by default, hindering guests from joining the meeting.

### **Incorrect information provided:**

There are few things as frustrating as trying to log onto your virtual meeting and it not working. Then it turns out you were given the incorrect links and passwords. This causes the employees to struggle as they are trying to find the correct information and it wastes time.

### **Inexperience with online meeting tech:**

This happens when employees are new to the tech that you are used to using in your virtual meetings. This causes delays as the employee needs help to set everything up before they can join the meeting. This can also happen when they employee does not have the correct tech needed to successfully join and participate in the meeting

### **Screen sharing fail:**

We have all been in meetings where someone has tried to share their screen and it did not work. The person sharing gets confused and does not know how to fix the issue. They have to join again and restart the process or there is a delay and then the screen sharing works. There are three core use cases for screen sharing: presentation, collaboration, and technical assistance. If we put aside technical assistance, screen sharing is still being rejected in many situations perpetuating the continued use of email as a document-sharing tool (30% of all employees), despite email's inherent problems: Email frequently stumbles with speed of transmission, file size, synchronized document navigation and compatibility on different device types – a key consideration on smartphones and tablets. Screen sharing is excessively complex because of the inherent technology. Users suffer from slow transmission rates and lags, bad resolution, sensitive data accidentally being shared, detached participants and an unprofessional presentation flow.

### **Sensitive data accidentally shared**

As directly stated by Demo desk, Even though most screen sharing applications today let you share just the application window, most users still share the entire desktop because it's more convenient. We have all been in those meetings where sensitive email notifications or embarrassing private chat messages were popping up in the corner. Apparently, it's happening so frequently that there are entire businesses tackling this problem (e.g. <https://muzzleapp.com> for Mac – check out their brilliant landing page). Presenters share sensitive data when fumbling around finding and going back and forth between multiple documents in private folders. After all, current screen sharing technology is not designed to have professional interactions with customers or business partners.

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## Virtual icebreakers:



Please note that these are directly reviewed and provided by (Mrvova, n.d.)

### Show me your workspace

One of the challenges of remote work is turning your home into a temporary office space. As your colleagues are joining the call, ask them to do a little virtual tour of their work station. Sharing a bit of your home with others is a nice way for your team to bond and helps start the meeting on a positive note. We recommend this icebreaker for smaller team meetings.

### Family portrait

Another way to have fun during a virtual meeting is to take a screenshot of everyone on a video chat. To spice things up, take a different one each time — make funny faces, bring in your pets, do a crazy gesture, you name it. Take inspiration from our APAC team and their cute heart symbols as they sent their love to the rest of their team who couldn't join them on the call. On top of all that, group photos also make nice content for your social media, internal newsletters, or Slack channels.

### One-word recap

You can also use word clouds to pick up your team's thoughts and feelings. Open your meeting with a question such as: "In one word, how would you describe the past week/month?". Or, you can even try something different like: "If you could describe last week/month in color, what color would it be?" This icebreaker will help you take a pulse check of the overall atmosphere in the team and detect possible downturns.

### Virtual body language

Having microphones muted during a video call is a good practice to avoid any disturbing background noises, but it often hinders spontaneous communication between people. Create a signal or multiple signals that will help people express themselves. For example, instead of clapping when celebrating something, shake hands in the air. Raise a hand into the

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camera when asking for a time to speak. To express love or happiness, do a little heart symbol by putting both hands together or a simple thumbs-up.

## Quiz me weekly

What better way to break the ice at the beginning of your team meeting than with a fun quiz? A friendly competition will energize your team and add a social element to your virtual meeting. For recurring meetings, you can turn it into a regular activity and run a quick quiz (1-3 questions will do) at the start of every meeting. Your colleagues will have something to look forward to every time the meeting is approaching.

## Mood barometer

A simple rating poll can help you check the pulse of your team and monitor their mental health. For example, gauge your team's general feeling by asking them something like: "On a scale of 1-7, how are you feeling today?". You can then use the results as a discussion starter and ask your colleagues something like: "I can see that there's definitely room for improvement there. Does anyone want to share their thoughts?"

## Let's get physical

Let's face it – working from home is a sedentary business so a small physical break can be priceless. Incentivize one of your more athletic colleagues to lead a 5-minute stretch exercise through video chat or simply encourage your colleagues to stand up from their desks and jump a couple of times. Some physical activity will fire up your teammates and clear their heads for a little while.

## Give kudos

We all need a little morale-booster now and then, especially when working in isolation. Give kudos to the heroes in your team and celebrate the ones who went the extra mile. Kick your meeting off by running a word cloud poll with a question "Who was your silent hero this month?" Or, you can make it even more personal with "If you could hug one person from the team, who would it be?" Acknowledging people for the effort they're doing is a wonderful way to start a meeting. Expect lots of hearty "aw-s" and "oh-s".

## Highlights sharing

Here's another way to lift people's spirits. Crowdsource your colleagues' personal or professional highlights of the last week or month using Slido Ideas. Before your meeting takes place, send your colleagues a link to your Slido event where they can post their top moments. Then, as you kick off the meeting, display the highlights on the screen and give a shout out to each one. It's sometimes good to remind people of all the remarkable work that they've done. For example, in our Slido marketing team, we share highlights every week as part of our weekly marketing meeting.

## Coffee time

Have you heard of Fika? It's a Swedish word often interpreted as "a coffee and cake break". For Swedes, however, it is much more than that. It's about taking a break from everything for a while and enjoying quality time with friends or colleagues over a cup of coffee or tea. You can also take Fika to an online environment. Before your meeting, or in between meetings, gather on a video chat with your teammates for an informal catch-up. Socializing, even if it's only through a screen, will help those working from home feel less isolated. For example, our Slido marketing team meets online for a coffee break every day at 2 PM.

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## Home fashion police

Here's another fun live poll to help you lighten the mood and loosen people up. Check up on your teammates' work-from-home attire. It's popular folklore that people love wearing PJs all day long during home offices. How does your team stand on this fashion statement? Another similarly popular activity is "Take a picture of your shoes" that is equally hilarious. Starting a meeting with some laughs and giggles will help your teammates feel more connected. For recurring meetings, come up with a different fun poll each time, here are some for your inspiration.

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